In some cases, the discussion about American support could be quite explicit. In May 1962, General Brij Mohan Kaul, chief of the general staff of the Indian army, asked visiting Ambassador at Large Bowles "whether [the US] would come to India's aid in [the] event [of an] open ChiCom armed invasion." The ambassador said he believed so. Then Kaul suggested secret joint contingency planning, even "if not fully sanctioned by Menon and/or Nehru." Bowles told Kaul to take the matter up with Galbraith. Subsequently, he recommended to the State Department that the approach be considered seriously.[232]

As the situation worsened, with a series of increasingly more serious border clashes after September 8, the US was careful about what it said publicly "so as to give the Chinese no pretext for alleging any American involvement." Beijing had continued to allege that the US was not just supporting India but inciting it. Privately, the US conveyed its "natural sympathy for the Indians and the problems posed by the Chinese intervention."[233] Responding to Indian requests, it also helped Delhi buy some military transport and communications-related equipment and supplied spare parts. Furthermore, while not offering specific aid, the US made clear to Nehru that it would be sympathetic to Indian requests. In preparation for an Indian ask for equipment "to cope with the Chinese threat," the State and Defense Departments looked into "the availability on short notice and on terms acceptable to India of transport, communications and other military equipment."[234]

On October 11, the US intelligence board's watch committee indicated no signs that a "Sino-Soviet Bloc country intends to initiate direct military action in the near future."[235] In mid-October, American officials assessed that neither China nor India "desires the conflict to become more extensive than the present skirmishing on the border." Analysts worried, however, that public opinion or questions of credibility on both sides could exacerbate the situation.[236] Even as Nehru worried about full-scale war breaking out[237] and Kennedy grappled with the Cuban missile crisis, on October 18, the Chinese central military committee formally approved a "self defence counterattack war."[238] Two days later, there was a major Chinese offensive in both the eastern and western sectors.

The War and India's Last Best Option: The US